Horde Cadet

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/51198082.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Fluff, Fluff and Angst, Sheratober (She-Ra), Emotional Baggage, Rivalry, Falling In Love, Fate & Destiny

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2023-10-29 Words: 3,389 Chapters: 1/1

Horde Cadet

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/51198082.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Fluff, Fluff and Angst, Sheratober (She-Ra), Emotional Baggage, Rivalry, Falling In Love, Fate & Destiny

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2023-10-29 Words: 3,389 Chapters: 1/1

Horde Cadet

by Largemovingtorb

Summary

While searching for the means to beat her prime competitor, Horde cadet Catra discovers something else—a lost and lonely balcony. In finding this hidden refuge, Catra learns that perhaps the key to her success might not lie in supremacy, but in a better way. One that runs counter to her Horde training.

Notes

This story was written for ilikeyoucatradora's Shera-Tober '23 and was done in collaboration with Miledibuja.

See the end of the work for more notes

Steadily, Catra inserted a clawed foot in the space between two pipes, twisting it slightly to gain purchase in the vertical slice. Carefully, she found a spot for her other foot, allowing her legs to take the weight away from her arms.

Ugh, I really have to work on my upper body strength, the young Horde cadet thought, peering up at her shaking limbs. They were both so thin, the arms of a youth who had just reached the cusp of adolescence. But that was no consolation to her—she wanted to be STRONG. Catra would have to be, especially if she wanted to be Force Captain.

*I will have to be strong if I'm ever going to beat… **her**.* She thought with annoyance.

A gust of wind caught Catra's attention, making the structure she clung to creak and moan. She shut her eyes as the long stone-gray mane of hair blew back into her face—but stinging eyes were not the reason she did not want to see.

I'm still afraid of heights, though. Don't look down, don't look down, don't look down, don't look, don't look down,

But to be fair to her growing body, Catra had to admit that she had noticed positive changes—for one, her equilibrium was becoming more aligned; no longer was she the clumsy child who would fall on the balance beam during drills, earning band-aids for cut knees. Catra could now easily traverse the narrow edge, even doing handstands and somersaults to the drill instructor's annoyance.

Catra was also becoming faster—much faster. Whenever another cadet was pitted against her for sparring, their attempts to hit her came off as clumsy and slow. Catra could easily beat almost anyone who faced her in combat—and she was only getting better.

Unable to resist the urge any longer, Catra peered down between her legs—right away, letting out a small shriek as a wave of

vertigo washed over her senses, immediately followed by a fit of nausea.

She was so high up now—much farther than she had dared in the past. The walkway where her climb had begun was below her and off to the right. It seemed so far away now and from another lifetime—one where another version of herself had existed, a Horde cadet who was much braver than the one currently clutching with tense claws to a bunch of rusty old pipes. Catra tried to channel that person who, not too long ago, had considered the climb to lofty heights.

But as soon as she reclaimed a small measure of that old courage, Catra's focus drifted to what was immediately below her.

Nothing.

Well, nothing for about three thousand handspans before hitting the floor of the vast Fright Zone—a fall not even Catra could survive.

Get a grip, get a grip, get a grip… don't think about becoming Catra-paste… she thought, redirecting her awareness up to the grand cityscape that was the only home she knew.

Catra knew the Fright Zone was an ugly place; nestled within an ancient caldera, the base of operations for the Horde appeared as a maze of conduits—here and there forming into bulbous conglomerations that acted as the buildings for the Horde. It was so dark and dingy in aspect—the constant smelting creating a haze of ever-present smog that cast the sun in blood red shroud.

But it was what was behind the unattractive façade of the Fright Zone that interested the young Horde cadet—*power.*

An eat-or-be-eaten mentality had been a part of Catra's life for as long as she could remember and was intrinsic to everything they did as cadets. It was a doctrine of pain passed down from Hordak to be prosecuted by every member of the Horde—from Shadow Weaver to the Force Captains and down to the lowest minion—

everyone was expected to fall into line. Those that didn't were never seen nor spoken of again—failures who were too weak to hack it.

That would not be Catra; not only did she know how to toe the line just enough to keep from being discarded, but she also knew the key to success—ruthlessness. She recognized that trait in every successful Force Captain and was on the receiving end of it every day in the form of Shadow Weaver. The young Horde cadet also knew that there was only one way to get out from under such oppression—to be the one on top. To be the strongest, the meanest, and the cruelest—just like Hordak and Shadow Weaver.

Yes, the Horde personified raw strength, and Catra desired to be a part of that. She would rise through the ranks of its military infrastructure, even replacing Hordak one day.

Horde Queen Catra! She thought to herself with a grin. *That would really impress—*

Catra clamped down on that train of thought, shaking her head with a growl.

No. You are doing this for yourself. Not her. You're doing this to prove that you're better than her. Remember that!

But try as she might, Catra could not get the image of a pretty blonde-haired girl out of her mind.

Adora.

Her friend was never far from her thoughts—Catra's best and ONLY friend in all of the Horde. Sure, there were others—Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle—but their friendship felt different to Catra, not as special as the one she had with Adora. For as long as Catra could remember, Adora had been there, by her side, through thick and thin. But lately…

Lately, Adora had become a hindrance to Catra's rise to power—plain and simple.

Adora was the top cadet in their class; she was the best at armed and unarmed combat and had mastered advanced tactics by the age of eight. Adora was a natural leader, and it was rumored that Hordak himself had his eye on her progress through the Horde officer training program.

Worst of all and perhaps the most unfair, Shadow Weaver was always quick to praise Adora while criticizing Catra in the same breath—usually for something that both girls were doing the same. Adora could orally recount the Great Battle of the Bibbets and receive full marks from Shadow Weaver. But when Catra recited the exact same thing, she would be lucky to receive half as much credit from the old witch.

"It's always something I'm doing wrong," Catra growled out loud, digging her claws into the metal of her perch.

The thought of Shadow Weaver brought forth a rich spike of anger within Catra, causing her to turn her attention back to her goal.

Up above and to the left, the young Horde cadet could make out the railing of a platform that jutted out from the assembly of pipes, sheet metal, and rivets she was currently scaling. It was such an architectural oddity to Catra; here at the top of a heap of junk was a viewing balcony—for what purpose she could not discern. Catra had searched all around the base of this strange balcony and could not find any means of reaching it—no stairs, ladder, or elevator. Nothing. She had even dug up the old blueprints that whatever madperson had put together when designing the Fright Zone, finding no record of any balcony in this quadrant.

Catra decided she just had to reach this normally unobtainable pinnacle, so overcome was she by feline curiosity. She also reasoned that if she were to one day become ruler of the Horde, Catra would have to become master of this territory called the Fright Zone. No part of it would be unknown to her; wherever

Catra wanted to go, the Fright Zone would open the way to her, revealing all its secrets.

First, I have to make sure I don't fall to my death, the young Horde cadet thought, reaching up for the next handhold. *I won't become ruler of anything if I become Catra-paste.*

Pulling herself up, Catra shimmied across an exposed duct, searching upwards for the next avenue of ascension.

Ugh, I don't see anything… there is a blasted overhang above me, and there aren't any places to grab onto.

Catra shifted her gaze to the underside of the platform—there, loops of thick cabling hung like lazy vines beneath a heavy tree branch. They were perhaps twenty handspans from where Catra crouched on a girder, swaying gently in a rare breeze that had wafted into the Fright Zone.

Those look like they could hold me, Catra considered, *but can I jump that far?*

Summoning all her courage and gathering all of her resolve, Catra's legs tensed as her tail twitched in anticipation of the leap.

"One, two, THREE!" Catra cried, unleashing the gathered energy within her feline muscles and tendons to spring forward, hands outstretched to grasp.

"Yow!" Catra cried in alarm as the heavy cabling slapped her in the face, surprising the young Horde cadet. Catra hurriedly clutched the sinewy cord, wrapping her legs around it as she began to sway back and forth, considering her point of origin.

Wow! I did that so easily! I could totally jump father if I wanted to! She thought with a grin.

Still smiling, Catra shimmied the length of the cabling, beginning in a horizontal position and slowly orientating to a vertical one as she neared the point it attached to the underside of the platform.

Reaching the end, Catra discerned the lip of the balcony was not far—and, stretching her skinny arms—seized the edge with one hand and then the other.

Now supporting her entire weight with mere fingertips, Catra once again concentrated on a single image—one of a crimson-masked face, eyes narrowed in disapproval for an unwanted child. Immediately, the rage came back, fiery and hot, igniting the muscles in her arms—Catra began to haul herself up, growling and spitting with wrath. When she was near enough, the young Horde cadet grabbed the cross brace of the railing, hooking a leg over the edge to push herself up even further. Now fully past the lip of the platform and with both feet securely under her, it was a simple matter for Catra to hop over the balustrade and land safely on her goal.

"That was so easy!" Catra stated, hands on hips as she regarded her objective.

It was just as she suspected: just a lonely and seemingly useless balcony, jutting out from the top of a mountain of garbage—but there was a story there. Blaster scorch marks were everywhere, and sections of the heavy-gauge metal railing had been bent outward, indicating that it had withstood some past trauma. Catra could also tell that the platform had once been built for some other purpose; the metal panels lining the deck appeared to be perforated, most likely to increase tractability. Whatever this balcony had been a part of, it was not meant to be stationary—perhaps it was once installed within an ocean-going vessel or something even grander; the young Horde cadet's mind spun with the possibilities. But whatever its history, the balcony had been discarded here haphazardly—just meaningless scrap from another person's grand ambitions.

"That's okay; when I'm Horde Queen Catra, I will have this transported to my new fortress," Catra said, nodding to herself.

The young Horde cadet made her way to the end of the derelict platform, casting her gaze outwards toward the cityscape of the

Fright Zone. She pictured a wide boulevard below her, masses of Horde troopers marching alongside tanks and other vehicles of destruction, all moving as one under her direction. Catra held a fist in the air, and in her mind's eye, the many soldiers below her copied the salute as they chanted—*all hail the Horde Queen!*

Catra laughed—she had done it! She had set a seemingly unattainable goal and had conquered it! This conquest would be her first of many successes; the young Horde cadet would scratch and claw her way to the top, and anyone who stood in her way would be crushed. She would even beat—

—a strange and unwanted sensation crept around the folds of Catra's senses, a pervasive anguish that tugged in her chest. She peered up into the sky, towards the caustic hue of the crimson sun, and squinted.

Is this what success is supposed to feel like? She thought, suddenly aware of the way the soft wind whistled over the balcony. The young Horde cadet hugged herself then, feeling suddenly desolate.

I started feeling this way when I thought of beating Adora. Catra considered. *Perhaps a part of me… I don't know… thinks I need her for some reason?*

She followed that train of thought, remembering how the Horde instructors taught that competition was the key to success. Fomenting rivalries between cadets helps them identify strengths and weaknesses, leading to innovation and creative problem-solving.

Why would that make me feel sad, though? Catra continued to rationale, tilting her head. *I could beat her over and over again and still have Adora as a rival.*

Losing focus on the logical aspect of her dilemma, Catra's brain diverted to a more abstract and emotional introspection.

Blonde hair and a beautiful smile. Clear blue eyes that sparkled whenever she giggled. I love it whenever she laughs—I love it even more when I make her do it! I live to make her laugh—it is the sunrise of my very existence—

Catra's eyes suddenly widened as she gritted her teeth.

"Ugh!" She cried, shaking her head so vigorously that her long ears flapped against her face.

What was that? That was so dumb! Whatever that was, it was totally not the reason I felt sad—it couldn't be! Catra reasoned to herself*.*

The young Horde cadet considered the platform once more, imagining her competitor trying to reach this point without her natural-born advantages.

As soon as that notion materialized in her young mind, a sly grin spread across Catra's lips.

"Let's see how good the number one cadet really is,"

* * *

Steadily, Catra inserted a clawed foot in the space between two pipes, twisting it slightly to gain purchase in the vertical slice. Carefully, she found another spot for her other foot, allowing her legs to take the weight away from her arms.

Okay, just like before, pull myself up to the duct—cross it—and then jump to the—

"Hey! Why are you going that way!?" A voice called, yanking Catra out of her concentration.

With a hiss of irritation, Catra spotted Adora over to her right—the other Horde cadet was easily at the same level as her and was grasping a hold with one hand as she waved with the other.

“How did you—?!” Catra began to spit. “Never mind! Why aren’t you following me? Didn’t I tell you I climbed this already and knew the way?”

Adora gaped back at her incredulously. “Because that way is dumb, Catra! My way is easier—come and look!”

Growling with annoyance, Catra shimmied her way over to the other cadet’s position, muttering under her breath the whole way.

“My way is easier. Look at me and my stupid hair poof—meh, meh, meh, meh,” she griped.

But as soon as Catra made it to Adora’s position, she noticed it instantly; following the structure's backside, there were just as many hand and foot holds—but instead of an overhang near the top, it crested into a gradual hump that could be easily climbed. There was no need to risk her neck by leaping for the cabling hanging below the platform; this way was totally better.

How did I not notice this!? Catra seethed to herself.

“See, Catra? This way is better!” Adora cajoled.

Catra blew a raspberry through her lips and rolled her eyes.

“Yeah, I guess.” She conceded. “If you like going the easy way and are afraid of challenges,”

Adora stuck her tongue out in response, making Catra want to giggle. Instead, she leered at the other Horde cadet.

“Come on! Let's see if you are as fast as you are stupid! Race ya!” Catra yelled, beginning to scramble as fast as she could up a frame support.

“Hey! No fair, you cheater!” Adora cried, trying to keep up. But it was no use; Catra was in her confident stride, leaping from pipe to beam to conduit with her natural-born agility. She was soon at

the top and, with hands on hips, watched her fellow cadet follow in her wake, an arrogant smirk not far from her lips.

“You’re a jerk, Catra!” Adora huffed as she came to the brink of the climb.

Catra frowned at this, not liking how upset her fellow cadet was.

“Whatever… I guess I will admit your way was better,” she conceded.

“You bet it was!” Adora said, still a little angry but now amenable.

Catra was confused by the relief she felt, deciding to caulk it up to the excitement of the race she just won.

“Come on, dummy! Check this out!” Catra said, beckoning Adora to follow. The two Horde cadets halted at the balcony's edge, leaning on the railing to consider the view before them.

“Wow! This is a really neat spot you found!” Adora breathed, wide-eyed.

“I know, right?” Catra said, watching her friend from the corner of her eye. The recent exertion had cast a rosy hue on Adora’s cheeks, a color that added a vibrant glow to her face. It looked really… *nice.*

“What made you want to come up here, Catra?” Adora said, turning to face the other cadet.

Feeling a heat in her face, Catra cast her gaze back to the cityscape, suddenly clumsy and unsure of her words. The honest truth came out, unbidden.

“I wanted to test myself. To find out if I was good enough…” she said, embarrassed.

“Good enough for what?” Adora asked, head cocked in open curiosity.

Catra found she couldn't look at her fellow cadet, afraid of the effect it would have on her ability to speak coherently.

"I want to be at the top one day—of the Horde, I mean. I want to rule everything." She said simply.

Adora's mouth opened in a soundless 'O' of comprehension, making Catra want to wince at the stupidity of admitting her true intentions to the Horde's top cadet.

"That's a pretty good goal, Catra. I like it!" Adora said, nodding emphatically.

"Really?" Catra responded, unsure if the other was mocking her or not.

"Yeah! Totally!" Adora said. "Since we are best friends, I will help you do it, too! What do you think?"

Catra was dumbstruck by the openhearted offer—not only was Adora suggesting she would assist her friend to rise through the ranks, but also step aside so Catra could rule. After all, Adora would have to; she was number one in their class.

The Horde cadet who had started this whole exercise as a means to prove her superiority over her best friend was suddenly immersed in an overwhelming feeling of gratitude. At the periphery of this benign emotion was something else… almost like friendship… but *sweeter*. To Catra, it felt better than anything she had experienced in all of her young life.

"So, what do you say, dummy? Do you want my help or not?" Adora asked, a little annoyed her fellow cadet had not answered.

Catra could not help the warm grin spreading across her face. She shook her head.

"No, I have a better idea. How about you and I make it to the top together—as equals! We can rule the Horde as two Queens!" She said.

Adora’s face blossomed into instant excitement. “Yeah!!!” She said, hopping up and down on the balls of her feet excitedly.

“What do you say, Horde Cadet Adora? You and me?” Catra asked, holding out a hand.

“You bet, Horde Cadet Catra! You and me, we’re gonna be Horde Queens!” Adora said, taking the other’s hand and shaking it.

With the pact sealed, the two friends returned to regard their destined kingdom, both excited for the prospects of the future. Catra turned to Adora, placing a friendly hand on her shoulder and gently squeezing it.

“You and me are going to do great things, Adora. I can feel it,”

THE END


THIS PLACE YOU FOUND IS AMAIZING CATRA!
RIGHT AT THE TOP.
THE PERFECT SPOT FOR WORLD RULERS LIKE US.
@MILEDIBUJA

End Notes

The illustration was done by Miledibuja on Twitter, Instagram, and Tumblr. Her art was the inspiration and basis for this story.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!